

ESSENTIAL SKILL

Shelter

Stay Dry. Stay Safe. Hold the Temperature.

Shelter is more than having a roof over your head. A useful emergency shelter must protect you from cold, heat, wind, rain, snow, flooding, unsafe air, and structural hazards.

FIRST MAKE IT SAFE. THEN MAKE IT COMFORTABLE.

IMMEDIATE ACTION

If you need shelter right now

1

Get away from immediate danger.

Do not remain in a building threatened by fire, flooding, collapse, gas leaks, heavy smoke, or other obvious hazards.

2

Get dry and out of the wind.

Wet clothing and wind can remove body heat surprisingly quickly.

3

Choose the safest available space.

4

Keep people together when practical.

5

Heat the people and occupied space rather than trying to heat an entire building.

CHOOSE CAREFULLY

The best part of a building

In a long power outage, some rooms will be much easier to live in than others. Look for a space that is:

- Dry.
- Structurally sound.
- Protected from wind.
- Reasonably insulated.
- Large enough for its occupants.
- Close to necessary supplies.
- Able to be safely ventilated.

Interior rooms often lose less heat than exposed rooms with many windows.

What about basements?

The surrounding earth can help moderate temperature, but a basement is only useful if it is safe.

☐ Does it flood?

☐ Is it dry and free of mold?

☐ Is there adequate ventilation?

☐ Are there safe exits?

☐ Are heating appliances properly vented?

☐ Is there a carbon-monoxide alarm?

☐ Is the structure sound?

A basement that may flood should not be considered a safe shelter during a flood emergency.

CONSERVE BODY HEAT

In cold weather

The first goal is not to make the room feel like summer. The goal is to keep people safely warm.

- Wear layers, hats, and dry socks.
- Use blankets and sleeping bags.
- Place rugs or padding beneath sleeping areas.
- Close off unused rooms when appropriate.
- Concentrate people in a smaller safe living area.

People lose heat to cold floors as well as cold air.

WARM THE PERSON BEFORE THE ROOM

Dry body layers

Base layers, dry socks, and hat

Insulating cover

Blankets or sleeping bag around the person

Floor barrier

Rugs, pads, cardboard, or other dry insulation underneath

Keep people dry

Wet clothing can become dangerous in cool weather. Hypothermia can occur even above 40°F when someone becomes chilled from rain, sweat, or immersion.

STEP 1 Get the person out of the wind.

STEP 2 Remove wet clothing when dry replacements are available.

STEP 3 Put on dry layers.

STEP 4 Wrap the person in blankets or a sleeping bag.

STEP 5 Warm the person gradually.

RECOGNIZE THE WARNING SIGNS

Watch for hypothermia

Shivering

Extreme tiredness

Confusion

Fumbling hands

Slurred speech

Drowsiness

Severe hypothermia is a medical emergency. Do not assume that a confused or unusually sleepy person is simply tired.

PEOPLE NEED CLEAN AIR

Don't seal the room too tightly

Stopping drafts can conserve heat, but people still need safe air. Be especially careful with wood stoves, fireplaces, fuel-burning heaters, and any combustion appliance.

Never block required vents or flues. Have working smoke and carbon-monoxide alarms.

Indoor combustion can produce deadly carbon monoxide, which cannot be seen or smelled.

PREVENT DANGEROUS OVERHEATING

In hot weather

- Use the coolest part of the building.
- Stay out of direct sunlight and close sun-facing shades.
- Use ventilation when outdoor conditions allow.
- Reduce unnecessary physical activity.
- Drink adequate safe water.
- Move if the building becomes dangerously hot.

Sometimes the safest shelter is somewhere else.

KEEP IT SIMPLE

Your sleeping area

An emergency sleeping space does not have to look like a bedroom. You mainly need:

- A dry location with insulation from the floor.
- Blankets, sleeping bags, and warm clothing.
- Enough space to lie down safely.
- A clear path to the exit.

Avoid blocking doors, stairs, hallways, or emergency exits.

RECOMMENDED SUPPLIES

Simple shelter kit

☐ Blankets

☐ Sleeping bags

☐ Warm clothing

☐ Hats and gloves

☐ Dry socks

☐ Tarps

☐ Rope or cord

☐ Plastic sheeting

☐ Duct tape

☐ Flashlights or headlamps

☐ Battery-powered lights

☐ Smoke alarms

☐ Carbon-monoxide alarms

☐ Fire extinguisher

☐ Basic hand tools

☐ First-aid kit

PROTECT, BUT DO NOT TAKE RISKS

Temporary repairs

After a storm, a tarp, plastic sheeting, rope, and basic tools may temporarily protect a damaged area from rain, snow, wind, or further water damage.

Shelter is replaceable. People are not.

Do not climb onto an unsafe roof or enter a damaged structure just to make a repair.

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

- ✗ Stay in a building that appears structurally unsafe.
- ✗ Use a basement that is flooding or likely to flood.
- ✗ Ignore mold or serious dampness.
- ✗ Sleep directly on a very cold floor when insulation is available.
- ✗ Stay in wet clothing.
- ✗ Block required ventilation to save heat.
- ✗ Use unsafe heating equipment indoors.
- ✗ Block exits with beds, supplies, or furniture.
- ✗ Heat an entire large building when one safe room would do.

✗ Assume staying home is always safer than leaving.

TRY THIS NOW

Shelter practice

Imagine the electricity and normal heat will be off for three days. Walk through your home or building and choose the room or area you would use.

1. Is it dry and protected from wind?
2. Can everyone fit?
3. How would everyone stay warm?
4. What would people sleep on?
5. Where are the blankets?
6. Is there safe ventilation?
7. Where are the smoke and carbon-monoxide alarms?
8. Is there more than one way out?
9. What would make everyone leave the building?

If you cannot answer these questions now, you know what needs attention.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I know the safest areas of my home or building.

☐ I know whether my basement floods.

☐ I have checked for moisture and mold.

☐ I have enough blankets, sleeping bags, and warm dry clothing.

☐ I can insulate sleeping areas from a cold floor.

☐ I have working smoke and carbon-monoxide alarms.

☐ I know how I would safely heat the occupied area.

☐ I know when staying would become more dangerous than leaving.

REMEMBER

Shelter means dry, safe, and protected, not perfect comfort.

Warm the people before trying to warm the whole building.

If the shelter itself becomes dangerous, leave.

GET SAFE. STAY DRY. HOLD THE TEMPERATURE.

Official guidance

Follow current local evacuation, weather, fire, and public-health instructions during an emergency.

FEMA: Basements and Safe Rooms(<https://www.fema.gov/node/my-house-has-basement-do-i-need-safe-room>)

CDC: Preventing Hypothermia(<https://www.cdc.gov/winter-weather/prevention/index.html>)

CDC: Carbon Monoxide Poisoning Basics(<https://www.cdc.gov/carbon-monoxide/about/index.html>)
